

15 Saithe in the Southern Celtic Sea and the English Channel, Bay of Biscay, Atlantic Iberian waters, Azores grounds

pok.27.7-10 – *Pollachius virens* in subareas 7-10

15.1 General

Saithe (*Pollachius virens*) is a large gadoid species that although primarily a cold water species, ranges from the Arctic through to the Iberian waters. There is a large saithe fishery in the North Sea, Skagerrak and West of Scotland which is assessed as an ICES category 1 stock. There are reported catches of saithe in the regions south of that stock, but ICES has not provided advice in these regions.

15.1.1 Stock Identification

There is some uncertainty on the stock identity in subareas 7-10 and due to the relatively low abundance in this region, assessment options are more limited in comparison to pok.27.3a46 and pok.27.1-2.

Saithe in subareas 7-10 has not previously been assessed by ICES and its status as a stock had not been considered until the Benchmark on Selected Gadoid Species WKBGAD (ICES 2024). There are questions and uncertainty as to whether the saithe 7-10 stock is a separate stock, or just the margins of the North Sea stock. The survey data show that there are catches in Subarea 7, but there are often far higher catches by the same surveys in both 6a and in the southern North Sea (Figure 15.1). This seems to back up the idea that Subarea 7 is an extension of the wider stock. ICES estimates of catches are shown in Figure 15.4. By combining the survey data, it shows the higher catches further north, but also that there are no small fish in Subarea 7 and they only show up in 7 as they get larger. The absence of small fish tentatively suggests that the saithe found in Subarea 7 are older fish from the wider stock that are migrating south occasionally. There are studies showing that there is significant migration of saithe within the Northeast Atlantic area, but little that is specific with regards to Subarea 7 (Homrum *et al.* 2013). There is also little genetic work for this area, although it has been concluded that saithe in areas 2a-south, 4 and 6a appear to be of the same genetic cluster, whilst 6b may be somewhat genetically isolated (Saha *et al.* 2015).

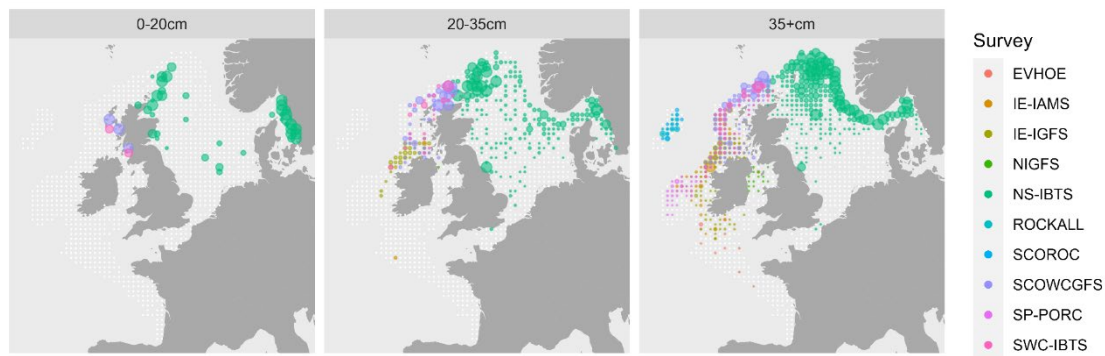


Figure 15.1. Saithe in Subareas 7-10. Survey data of saithe catches broken down by size class.

The benchmark concluded that in all likelihood the saithe in subareas 7-10 were part of the North Sea 3a46 stock, but that evidence was tentative (ICES, 2024). There is no indication whether the fish found in 7-10 are temporary migrants who return to spawn further north, or if they are (presumably unsuccessfully) breeding in the area and are a sink population.

Nevertheless, it was agreed that the stock could be assessed in its own right. Due to the potential links with the North Sea saithe stock, it was recommended that it be assessed at WGNSSK to maintain that link.

15.1.2 Ecosystem Aspects

No new information on ecosystem aspects was presented at WGNSSK in 2025.

15.1.3 Fisheries

Saithe is mainly caught by Ireland (Table 15.1). Several countries are involved in the fisheries: Belgium, Faeroe Islands, France, Ireland, The Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, Spain and UK (England, Wales, Northern Ireland, Channel Islands, Isle of Man and Scotland). Ireland landed most saithe in 2024 (48%), followed by France (33%) and the UK (15.2%).

Over the last 5 years (2020-2024) Ireland landed most saithe (63%), followed by France (21%) and the UK (13%).

Nearly 97% of the catches in recent years have come from Subarea 7, with 2.2% from Subarea 8 (Figure 15.2). Historically, subarea 8 was more important, but that has changed considerably in the last 20 years (ICES, 2024).

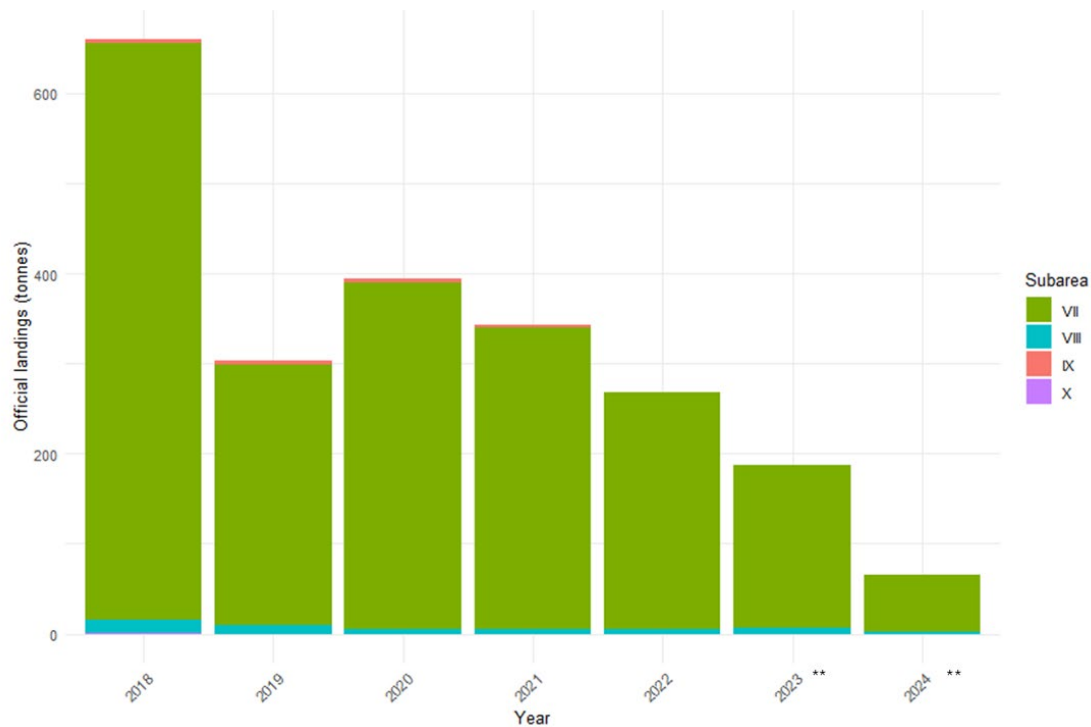


Figure 15.2. Saithe in Subareas 7-10. Official landings 2018-2024 (Tonnes). ** Preliminary landings for 2023 and 2024.

Landings from inside the NEAFC regulatory areas (RAs; subdivisions 27.10.a1 and 27.9.b.1) for saithe as estimated by ICES and based on official landings reported by area by countries participating in the fishery, as well as total declared landings was reported only in 2022 (Table 15.5) of less than 1% (0.02 t) of the total landings (272 t).

15.1.4 ICES advice for the previous year

ICES has not previously provided advice for this stock.

15.2 Management

This stock is managed by a TAC. In 2024 and 2025, the TAC was set at 1525t. This was down on previous years where a TAC of 2541t had been set from 2022-2023. The TAC has always been set higher than the catch (Figure 15.3 and Table 15.4).

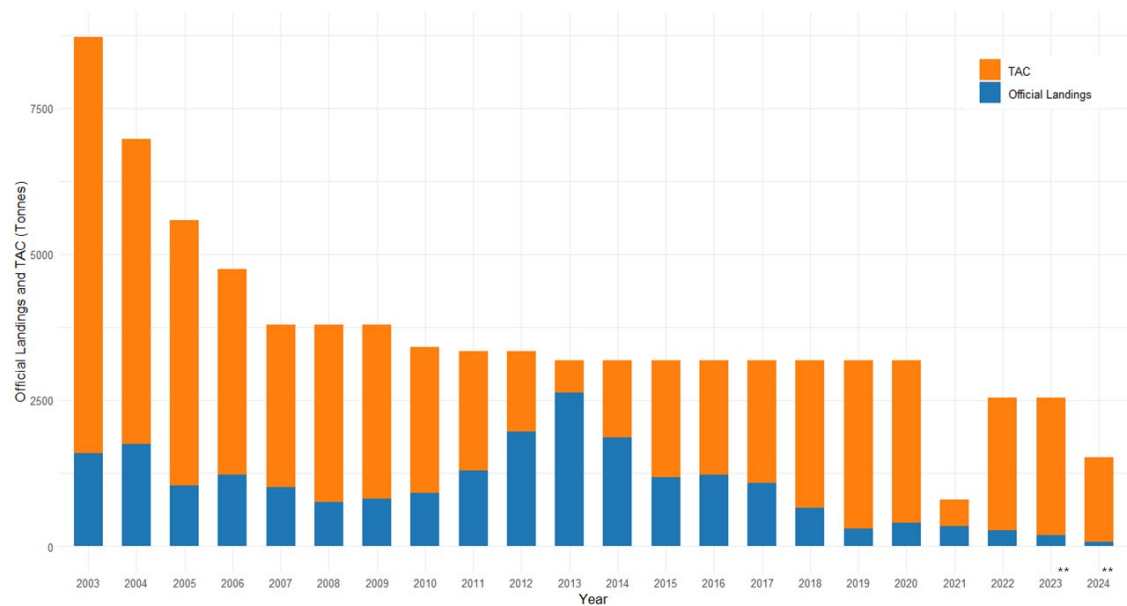


Figure 15.3. Saithe in Subareas 7-10. Official landings and TAC 2003-2022 (Tonnes). ** Preliminary landings for 2023 and 2024.

15.3 Data Available

15.3.1 Catch

ICES estimated landings and discards are presented in Table 15.2 and Figure 15.4.

Most saithe are caught by gillnets (58% of catches) or otter trawls (24%) (Table 15.3).

InterCatch data is available from 2003 and in that time period catches closely align with the official landings (Figure 15.3 and Figure 15.4). In the last 5 years, Ireland has recorded 68% of landings, with France and the UK contributing 16 and 13% respectively. These proportions have changed significantly since 2003 when France reported 39% of landings and Ireland 51%.

Discards were raised by the corresponding metier/area/quarter combination.

In the last 5 years (2020-2024) 97% of the catches have come from Subarea 7, with 2% from Subarea 8 (Figure 15.4). Historically, subarea 8 was more important, but that has changed considerably in the last 20 years.

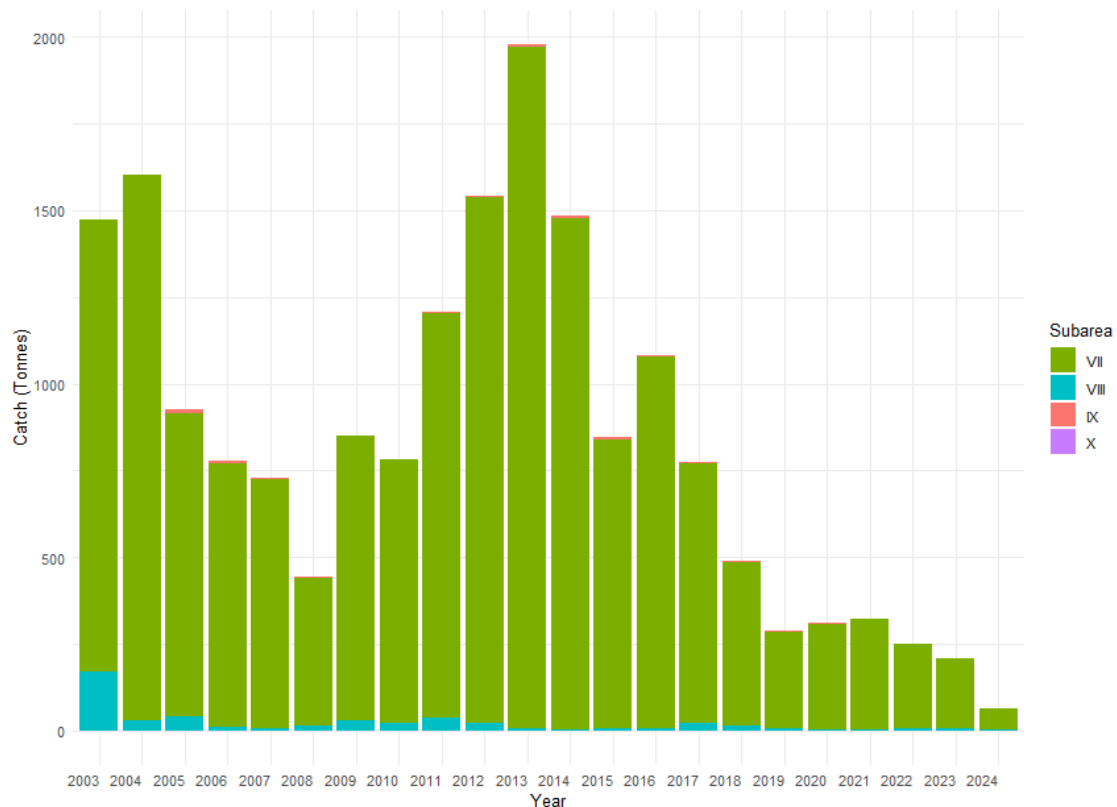


Figure 15.4. Saithe in Subareas 7-10. Saithe catches (landings and discards) by Subarea from InterCatch. Discards are provided in Table 15.2.

15.3.2 Age Composition

There is limited age data available for the catches. Only Ireland has submitted age data to InterCatch, primarily from gillnets (GNS). Age and length samples were raised to the catch by the corresponding metier/area/quarter combination. Where sampling was unavailable and borrowing from similar metiers was deemed inappropriate, no age length raising was done. Age data are not used in the assessment.

15.3.3 Length Composition

Ireland is the only country to submit length data to InterCatch. Age and length samples were raised to the catch by the corresponding metier/area/quarter combination.

Although the mean length has remained generally stable over the past 20 years (Figure 15.5), there has been a decline since 2014. This may indicate that the stock is being overfished.

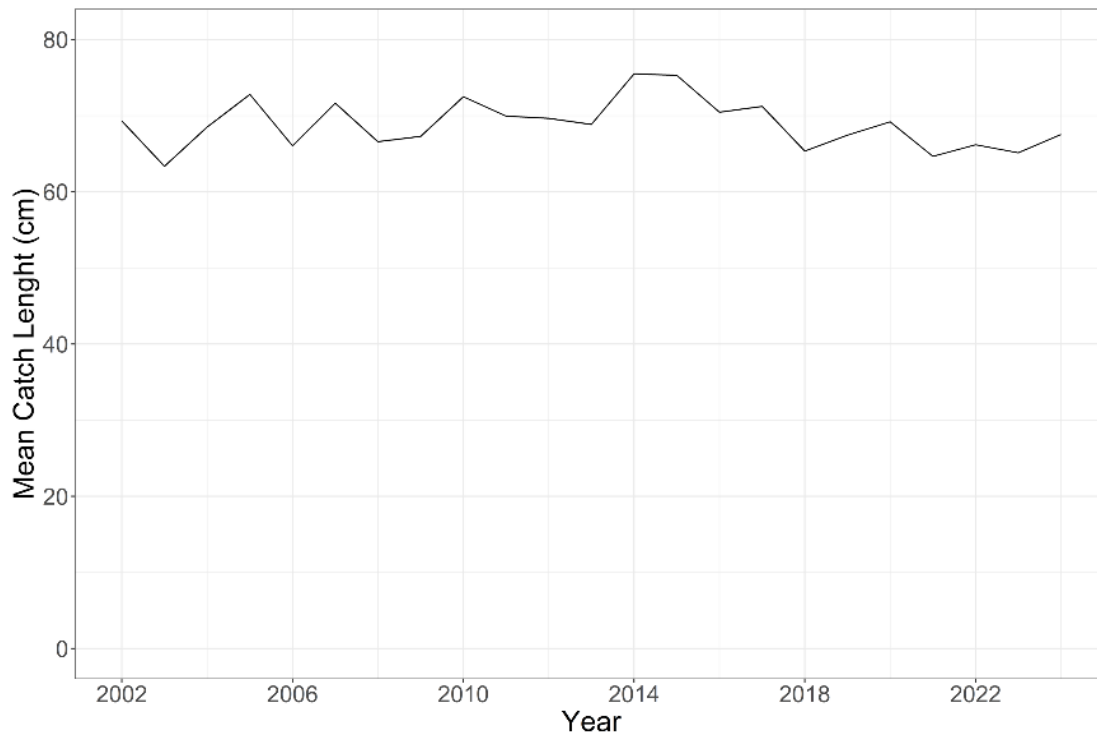


Figure 15.5. Saithe in Subareas 7-10. Mean catch length (cm).

15.3.4 Indices of abundance

There are many trawl surveys operating in subareas 7-10 and these were explored for saithe catches. Saithe was mainly caught in Subarea 7, and abundances per km swept area were estimated. The surveys with saithe catches were the Irish groundfish (IGFS), Irish Anglerfish and Megrim (IAMS), Spanish porcupine (PORC), Northern Irish groundfish (NIGFS) and the UK beam trawl survey (UK BTS) and the North Sea international bottom trawl survey (NS-IBTS in 7.d). The number and weight of saithe caught each year by the surveys are shown in Figure 15.6. Even combining 5 surveys, there are generally less than 100 saithe caught and the contribution from each survey varies hugely year by year.

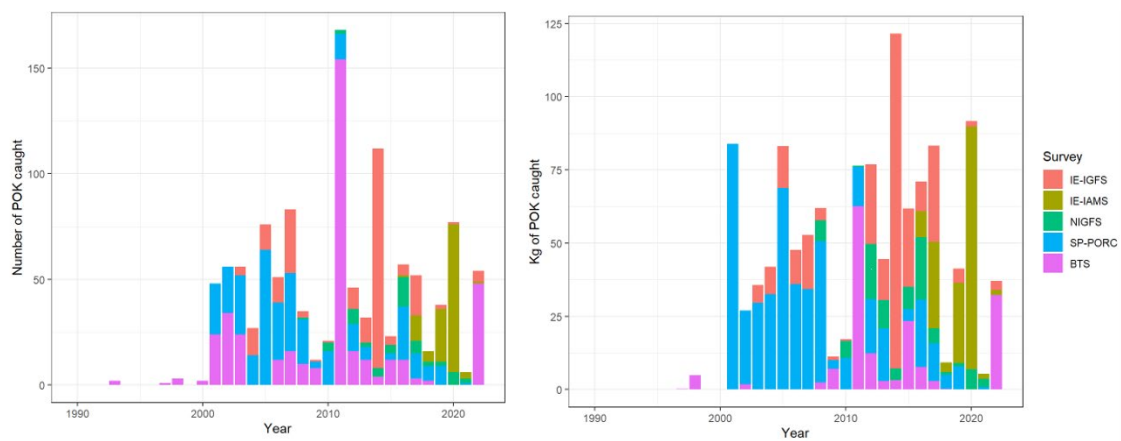


Figure 15.6. Saithe in Subareas 7-10. Combined survey data showing the number of saithe and the weight of saithe caught in subarea 7 (excluding NS-IBTS).

A few large saithe catches are driving the results and can be seen in the geographic data (Figure 15.1). It should be noted that in the instances where the surveys extended north into Subarea 6, significantly higher saithe catches were recorded there, indicating that the surveys were suitable and able to catch saithe, and their absence further south is likely real. The benchmark group determined that based on the scarcity and patchiness of saithe catches in the surveys no reliable index of abundance could be modelled in subareas 7-10 (ICES, 2024).

WKGBAD decided that because there was no targeted fishery in 7-10, and due to the complexity of the métiers landing saithe, no commercial CPUE index would be possible.

15.3.5 Quality of the assessment

This stock was assessed at a benchmark (WKBGAD) in 2024 (ICES, 2024). Insufficient data and lack of knowledge of the true stock identity result in this stock being assessed as a Category 5 stock (ICES, 2023).

15.4 Catch advice

ICES advises that when the precautionary approach (PA) is applied, catches in the years 2026-2028 should be no more than 146 tonnes.

Average of catch (2021-2024)	183 tonnes	
Discard rate	3.7%	
Precautionary buffer	Applied	0.8
Catch advice	146 tonnes	
Projected landings corresponding to the catch advice**	141 tonnes	
% total allowable catch (TAC) change***	-91%	

* Average catch (2022–2024) × precautionary buffer

** Catch advice × [1 – discard rate]

*** Advice value for 2026-2028 relative to the TAC value for 2025 (1 525 tonnes).

15.5 Status of the stock

The stock status is unknown. Overfishing is not believed to be taking place.

15.6 Management considerations

Stock identity is considered to be uncertain. The scarcity of samples means it is unlikely that age or length based assessments will be possible for this stock.

There is no target fishery for this stock. Saithe is taken as unintentional bycatch in mixed demersal fisheries and discards do occur, although reported numbers are low.

15.7 Benchmark issue list

15.7.1 Data

The largest issue affecting this stock assessment is the absence of catch information on small fish. Juvenile fish do not appear in either survey or catch data. The absence of this component means that a complete assessment of the stock is not possible as it is likely that a considerable proportion of the stock does not directly recruit to the stock area.

15.7.2 Assessment

No assessment model exists for this saithe stock. Once more data comes available for this stock, assessment methods could be investigated.

15.7.3 Forecast

There is no forecast for this saithe stock.

15.8 References

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15.9 Tables

Table 15.1. Saithe in subareas 7–10. History of commercial catch and landings; the official landings are presented for each country participating in the fishery. All weights are in tonnes.

Year	Belgium	Spain	France	Faroe Islands	Ireland	Netherlands	Norway	Portugal	UK**	UK (Scotland)	Official total
2003	3	9	457	0	754	0	0	8	342	24	1597
2004	1	3	764	0	629	0	3	11	307	361754	
2005	1	21	396	0	394	0	0	17	208	2	1039
2006	1	31	428	0	571	0	9	43	131	1	1216
2007	2	5	522	0	363	0	0	3	114	0	1010
2008	1	9	418	0	223	0	0	2	95	2	750
2009	2	4	319	1	346	0	0	3	128	2	804
2010	1	11	394	0	391	0	0	2	109	4	912
2011	1	15	358	0	832	0	0	4	87	2	1299
2012	2	1	518	0	1247	0	2	4	169	10	1953
2013	2	1	404	0	1899	0	0	7	307	4	2623
2014	2	7	161	0	1472	1	0	8	210	4	1864
2015	1	2	133	0	908	2	0	5	127	0	1178
2016	< 0.5	4	115	0	926	< 0.5	0	18	157	0	1220
2017	1	< 0.5	113	0	869	< 0.5	0	9	90	0	1082
2018	1	0	78	0	488	< 0.5	0	5	85	0	658
2019	1	13	87	0	136	1	0	4	62	0	303
2020	1	36	74	0	237	< 0.5	0	4	43	0	395
2021	1	< 0.5	59	0	247	< 0.5	0	2	33	0	342
2022	1	< 0.5	48	0	183	0	0	0	36	0	268
2023*	< 0.5	< 0.5	38	0	124	0	0	0	26	0	188
2024*	1	0	22	0	32	< 0.5	0	0	10	< 0.5	66

* Preliminary.

** England, Wales, Northern Ireland, Channel Islands, Isle of Man.

Table 15.2. Saithe in subareas 7–10. ICES discards, landings and catch estimates. All weights are in tonnes.

Year	ICES discards*	ICES landings	ICES estimated catch
2003	< 0.5	1475	1475
2004	< 0.5	1603	1603
2005	< 0.5	925	925
2006	5	773	778
2007	< 0.5	728	728
2008	< 0.5	442	442
2009	186	696	882
2010	102	704	806
2011	207	1043	1250
2012	83	1487	1570
2013	117	1889	2006
2014	176	1350	1526
2015	131	860	991
2016	144	954	1098
2017	30	760	790
2018	11	487	498
2019	2	314	316
2020	< 0.5	320	320
2021	4	356	360
2022	2	272	274
2023	21	188	209
2024	< 0.5	66	66

* Since 2009, discards include below minimum size (BMS) landings.

Table 15.3. Saithe in Subareas 7-10. ICES landings by gear.

Year	DRB	FPO	GNS	GTN	GTR	LHM	LHP	LLD	LLS	MIS	OTB	OTM	OTT	PS	PTB	PTM	SDN	SSC	TBB	Total
2003		<0.5	464		1	1			0	320	569		53			1		47	18	1475
2004		<0.5	381		1	1			0	168	964		42		<0.5			30	16	1603

Year	DRB	FPO	GNS	GTN	GTR	LHM	LHP	LLD	LLS	MIS	OTB	OTM	OTT	PS	PTB	PTM	SDN	SSC	TBB	Total
2005		<0.5	297		2	<0.5			1	109	462		21			0		19	14	925
2006			216		1	1			0	178	349		13					15	4	778
2007			223		5	9			4	66	386		16					16	2	728
2008	<0.5	<0.5	147		2	8			1	20	230		19					13	2	442
2009	<0.5		228	<0.5	2	1	<0.5		2	27	565		14	<0.5		16		24	2	881
2010		<0.5	289	<0.5	2	3			1	31	465		11					4	1	806
2011	<0.5	<0.5	278	1	2	1			1	45	738		23	<0.5	1		<0.5	159	2	1251
2012		<0.5	690	<0.5	4	2			0	61	681		22				<0.5	107	2	1570
2013	<0.5	<0.5	1052	<0.5	2	1			2	33	684		34				<0.5	195	2	2006
2014		<0.5	940	<0.5	1	1			1	36	445		20			0		78	3	1527
2015		<0.5	502	<0.5	3	1			1	24	420		15					22	3	991
2016		<0.5	510	<0.5	2	4			1	39	488	0	19			0		31	3	1098
2017	<0.5		482	<0.5	2	10			3	46	205		16			0		19	7	790
2018	<0.5	<0.5	317	<0.5	2	8		<0.5	4	18	128	0	7					11	3	498
2019	<0.5	<0.5	181	<0.5	1	7		<0.5	21	18	76		6			0		4	1	316
2020		1	196	<0.5	1	5			6	18	86		4				<0.5	2	1	321
2021		<0.5	234	<0.5	1	6	3		15	34	60		3			0	<0.5	3	1	361
2022		<0.5	198	<0.5	2	3	2		6	11	48		2			0		2	1	274
2023		<0.5	123		1	7	3		3	16	52		1			2		1	<0.5	208
2024		<0.5	37		1	4	2		<0.5	4	15		1					<0.5	1	66

Table 15.4. Saithe in Subareas 7-10. History of the TAC.

Year	TAC
2003	8710
2004	6968
2005	5574
2006	4738
2007	3789
2008	3790
2009	3790

Year	TAC
2010	3411
2011	3343
2012	3343
2013	3176
2014	3176
2015	3176
2016	3176
2017	3176
2018	3176
2019	3176
2020	3176
2021	795
2022	2541
2023	2541
2024	1525
2025	1525

Table 15.5. Saithe in subareas 7–10. Landings from inside and outside the NEAFC regulatory areas (RAs; subdivisions 27.10.a1 and 27.9.b.1) as estimated by ICES and based on official landings reported by area by countries participating in the fishery, as well as total declared landings. All weights are in tonnes.

Year	Inside the NEAFC RAs	Outside the NEAFC RAs	Total landings	Percentage inside the NEAFC RAs
2021	0	356	356	0
2022	0.02	272	272	< 1%
2023	0	188	188	0
2024	0	66	66	0

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